

Incident handler's journal

Incident response journal entries.

Date: 19 July 2026	Entry: 1
Description	Analysis of a ransomware incident at a small U.S. health care clinic. The clinic's files were encrypted after an employee downloaded a malicious attachment from a phishing email, halting business operations and blocking access to patient records. This entry documents the incident using the 5 W's.
Tool(s) used	None at this stage. This entry is a documentation and analysis exercise based on the reported scenario rather than a hands-on investigation. Tools that would support a real response include a SIEM for log analysis, endpoint detection and response for the affected workstations, and email security filtering to trace the phishing source.
The 5 W's	• Who: An organized ransomware group known to target the healthcare and transportation sectors. The attackers gained entry through targeted phishing emails sent to several employees. • What: A phishing email carried a malicious attachment that, once downloaded, installed malware on an employee's computer. The attackers deployed ransomware, which encrypted critical files. A ransom note demanded payment for the decryption key. • When: Tuesday at approximately 9:00 a.m., when employees found they could not access files such as medical records. • Where: On the network of a small U.S. health care clinic providing primary-care services. The compromise began on an employee workstation and spread to file systems holding patient data. • Why: The attackers were financially motivated and sought a ransom payment. The entry point was human: employees were tricked into downloading a malicious attachment.
Additional notes	The root cause was a human-targeted phishing email, so security awareness training and stronger email filtering are the first preventive priorities. Offline, tested backups would reduce the leverage of a ransom demand. Open questions: were files exfiltrated before encryption, which would make this a HIPAA-reportable breach, and was network segmentation in place to limit spread?

Date: 21 July 2026	Entry: 2
Description	Investigation and resolution of a phishing alert (ticket A-2703) at a financial services company, following the organization's phishing incident response playbook. The alert concerned a suspicious email attachment whose file hash had previously been verified as malicious.
Tool(s) used	Phishing incident response playbook and flowchart; the alert ticketing system. Threat intelligence such as VirusTotal for file-hash reputation, referenced from the earlier verification of the attachment hash.

The 5 W's	● Who: An external threat actor posing as a job applicant, "Clyde West" of "Def Communications," using a spoofed sender address to target the company's HR team. ● What: A phishing email delivered a password-protected executable (bfsvc.exe) disguised as a resume and cover letter. The file hash is confirmed malicious, and the recipient may have downloaded and opened the attachment. ● When: The email was sent on Wednesday, 20 July 2022 at 09:30 a.m.; ticket A-2703 was raised for investigation. ● Where: At a financial services company, targeting the HR mailbox (hr@inergy.com) through the mail server (SERVER-MAIL). The affected endpoint is the recipient employee's computer. ● Why: To trick an HR employee, who routinely opens resumes, into executing malware and gaining a foothold on the company network, likely for financial gain given the target sector.
Additional notes	The password-protected .exe is a deliberate evasion technique to bypass email scanning; no legitimate applicant sends a password-protected executable as a resume. Because the attachment is confirmed malicious, the playbook directs escalation to a level-two analyst rather than closure. Follow-up for tier two: did the endpoint execute the file, and does EDR show signs of compromise or lateral movement? The affected host should be isolated pending that review.